

Supporter as Studio: Generative AI, Decentralized Production, and the Hybrid Media System in the 2026 Los Angeles Mayoral Race

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Abstract

This article uses the 2026 Los Angeles mayoral campaign of Spencer Pratt as a case through which to examine an emerging configuration of political media production: cinematic, culturally targeted campaign video generated by supporters using consumer-accessible generative AI tools and amplified through the candidate’s own social channels. Drawing on Chadwick’s (2017) hybrid media system framework and extending it with a “production layer” account informed by recent scholarship on generative AI in elections (Center for Media Engagement, 2024; Persily & Tucker, 2024), I argue that the Pratt ecosystem is best understood not as a campaign-versus-supporter dichotomy but as a three-tier production stack in which campaign-produced, supporter-generated, and journalist/influencer-amplified content interact through hybridized old and new media logics. Four artifacts anchor the analysis: a “Batman” / Dark Knight Rises–inspired AI ad produced by filmmaker Charlie Curran of Menace Studios (supporter-generated); a Spanish-language salsa music video, “Spencer, Saca La Bassura,” produced by the Latinos Por Pratt account (supporter-generated); a “Fresh Prince of Bel-Air” parody posted by Pratt himself (campaign-produced); and a campaign-commissioned “They Not Like Us” video. I argue that generative AI partially offsets traditional resource asymmetries by collapsing the cost of cinematic political video, but also introduces new failure modes—most visibly, cultural-fit failure when culturally distant supporters produce content for communities they do not belong to. I close by sketching what the configuration suggests for campaign infrastructure in 2028 and identifying three open empirical questions for the field: persuasion versus consolidation, attribution and accountability under conditions of distributed authorship, and the durability of “AI slop” as an engagement strategy. The article is intended as a generative case rather than a settled finding, and pairs throughout with explicit caveats about the soft causal relationship between virality and electoral outcomes.

Keywords: generative AI, hybrid media system, political communication, campaign advertising, supporter-generated content, decentralized production, Los Angeles, mayoral politics

1. Introduction

In the spring of 2026, a Los Angeles–based AI filmmaker with a four-person studio uploaded a ninety-second video to X. It cast the city as Christopher Nolan’s Gotham, ruled by an elite of partying French aristocrats: Mayor Karen Bass in Joker makeup, Governor Gavin Newsom eating cake, former Vice President Kamala Harris chugging vodka. Citizens were dragged before the elites, pleading for help with homelessness and wildfire recovery, and ridiculed for their trouble. Then a caped figure, dressed unmistakably as Batman, led a diverse crowd into the chamber to pelt the rulers with tomatoes and reclaim the city. The figure was Spencer Pratt, the reality television personality then running as a Republican to unseat Bass in the city’s nonpartisan mayoral primary. Within roughly twenty-four hours of being posted, the video had been viewed nearly 3.9 million times on X and reposted some 10,000 times (Hollywood Reporter, May 2026). Within days, Jeb Bush had called it “maybe the best political ad of the year”; Senator Ted Cruz and former Representative Matt Gaetz had circulated it; and the candidate it celebrated had reposted it from his own account.

The candidate had not commissioned the ad. The filmmaker, Charlie Curran of Menace Studios, was not employed by the campaign and would not respond to media requests for comment about his motivations (NBC News, May 2026). The video was, in the language Pratt himself used and later half-disowned, “fan-made” — although that phrase strains under the weight of what fan-made now means when consumer-accessible generative AI tools can produce cinematic political imagery that, by traditional production standards, would have required a midsized agency and a six-figure budget.

This article treats the Pratt campaign’s spring 2026 media ecosystem as a generative case for thinking about a configuration of political communication that is, on the evidence, emerging across multiple races and likely to become a structural feature of the 2028 cycle: campaigns whose most cinematically ambitious media is produced not by the campaign but by ideologically aligned supporters using generative AI tools, with the candidate functioning principally as an amplifier and cultural curator of that content. The configuration is neither wholly new nor wholly continuous with prior eras. It has clear antecedents in the user-generated political content of the 2008 and 2012 cycles, in the meme economies of 2016 and 2020, and in the influencer-mediated communication of the 2024 cycle. What is new is the *production capacity* now available to individual supporters with consumer hardware — a capacity that was not, even in 2024, sufficient to produce ninety seconds of broadcast-quality dystopian imagery on a weekend.

This article makes three contributions. *First*, it offers a three-tier typology of the Pratt media ecosystem (campaign-produced, supporter-generated, journalist/influencer amplification) that resists the common analytic temptation to flatten the case into a campaign-versus-supporter binary. The real story is hybrid: the campaign produces some content directly, commissions some content from outside vendors, has supporters generate other content unprompted, and amplifies across all three. *Second*, it argues that Chadwick’s (2017) hybrid media system framework remains the right master frame for the case, but that a useful refinement is to treat generative AI as a new *production layer* in that

system” an infrastructural change in who can produce broadcast-quality political video, distinct from changes in distribution and audience composition. *Third*, it is explicit about the limits of supporter-generated AI media as a campaign strategy. The Gustavo Arellano column on the campaign’s most successful Spanish-language artifact, “Spencer, Saca La Bassura,” argues that the video reads as Miami rather than Los Angeles” Cuban Spanish, salsa rather than corrido” and so misfires culturally in the city it claims to address. The case for supporter-generated AI as the future of campaign media must reckon with the case for cultural-fit failure as its characteristic vulnerability.

A note on framing. This article treats Pratt as an empirical case, not a normative endorsement. Pratt is a polarizing candidate; the AI artifacts that anchor the analysis include content his opponents have credibly described as violent in imagery (Bass, on CNN, May 2026) and content critics have credibly described as orientalizing or culturally mismatched (Arellano, May 2026). My argument is that the *configuration* on display” supporters producing cinematic AI political media at near-zero marginal cost, amplified by the candidate” is a phenomenon worth studying regardless of one’s view of the candidate. It is also a phenomenon that, if it becomes routine, raises serious questions for the field about authenticity, attribution, accountability, and the gap between viral attention and electoral conversion. The article addresses each of these, while flagging that the virality-to-votes link remains, on present evidence, weak and contested.

The article proceeds as follows. Section 2 situates the case in the relevant literatures on hybrid media systems, connective action, and the early empirical scholarship on generative AI in 2024-cycle campaigns. Section 3 describes the Pratt campaign and its media ecosystem in detail, with particular attention to the four artifacts that anchor the typology. Section 4 develops the typology and presents the central analytic argument: that generative AI is best understood as a new production layer in the hybrid media system. Section 5 turns forward to 2028, sketching the configuration’s likely trajectory and the questions the field is not yet positioned to answer. Section 6 concludes.

2. Theoretical and literature context

2.1 The hybrid media system as the master frame

The Pratt ecosystem invites, almost demands, Chadwick’s (2017) account of the hybrid media system. Chadwick’s argument” that contemporary political communication operates through the interaction and mutual remediation of older and newer media logics, neither of which simply supersedes the other” maps cleanly onto a campaign whose most viral artifact (the Batman ad) circulated on X but achieved consequential reach when it was picked up by *The Hollywood Reporter*, *TMZ*, *CBS Sacramento*, *NBC News*, and the *Daily Caller* in roughly the same forty-eight-hour window, and when conservative elites including Bush, Cruz, and Gaetz endorsed it in their own broadcast and social media presences. The video did not displace traditional media; it *required* traditional media to become a national rather than merely a regional event. Equally, the Bass campaign’s

response” via CNN’s Elex Michaelson, in a long-form interview format” made the AI artifacts national news through a thoroughly broadcast-era genre.

What the hybrid media system frame helps us see is that the Pratt case is not a story about social media replacing traditional media, or supporters replacing the campaign. It is a story about how the *interactions* among nodes have intensified, with each amplification across a layer (supporter to candidate, candidate to elite, elite to broadcast) shortening the time between artifact and event.

What it does not quite tell us, on its own, is what is genuinely new about the present configuration. Chadwick’s framework was developed in an era when the cost of producing cinematic political imagery still acted as a meaningful gate. Supporters could meme; they could film themselves; they could remix existing footage. They could not, as a rule, produce ninety seconds of dystopian original content with consistent character design and movie-grade lighting on a weekend. That gate has, in the most narrow technical sense, fallen. The hybrid media system frame is right about the relations among nodes; it now needs an account of what has changed at the production layer.

2.2 Connective action and the personalization of political expression

Bennett and Segerberg’s (2013) account of connective action” the loose, identity-anchored coordination of personalized political expression at scale” offers part of that account. The Latinos Por Pratt project, organized by a Cuban-American account holder splitting his time between Miami and Los Angeles, is connective action in a recognizable form. The “Spencer, Saca La Bassura” video, the “Wanted Out of Office” posters, the salsa instrumentation” these are personalized political expressions, anchored in identity, produced outside any formal campaign coordination, and circulated through networks of affinity.

What the connective action frame helps us see is that supporter-generated AI media is not a wholly novel phenomenon. It is a continuation of a logic the field has been tracking for a decade and a half, now operating with new tools. What it does not quite capture is the *production asymmetry* that generative AI introduces between connective actors. In a 2013 connective action episode, the production cost of a meme, a tweet, or a photographed protest sign was roughly even across participants. In a 2026 connective action episode involving generative AI, the production cost is technically low but the production *skill* is unevenly distributed. Charlie Curran is a commercial filmmaking veteran with an LA studio and four staff; Adrian Alvarez of Latinos Por Pratt is, on available reporting, working alone. The two artifacts they produced therefore look different not only in cultural fit (more on which below) but in cinematic register. Connective action explains *that* both produced; it requires extension to explain *what they were able to produce*.

2.3 Generative AI in campaigns: the early empirical record

The empirical scholarship on generative AI in 2024-cycle campaigns is still in formation, but several lines of work are directly relevant. The Center for Media Engagement’s (2024)

“Political Machines” report synthesized the early evidence on AI in the 2024 US elections and concluded that the most consequential use cases were not, as some pre-election commentary had feared, deepfake disinformation but rather *production-cost compression*: AI was used to lower the marginal cost of producing campaign-adjacent imagery, video, and copy. The Stanford / U. Chicago Harris pre-election working group (Persily & Tucker, 2024) reached related conclusions, emphasizing that the most important AI-related election dynamics would emerge in adjacent and supporter spaces rather than in formal campaign communications.

More recent work has begun to characterize the texture of AI-mediated political imagery. The arXiv “Generative Memesis” paper (2024) examined synthetic visuals and user engagement in the 2024 US presidential election and found that synthetic imagery often outperformed non-synthetic imagery on engagement metrics — though not, the authors emphasized, in ways that translated cleanly to persuasion. Van den Hoogen et al.’s (2025) work on European citizens’ *perceived* versus *actual* exposure to AI election content suggests a persistent gap between what audiences think they are seeing and what they are actually seeing — a gap with obvious implications for any “supporters as ad agency” thesis. If audiences are systematically miscalibrated about what is AI-generated and what is not, the meaning of the AI label as a signal of campaign authorship or supporter authorship becomes harder to pin down.

The Pratt case sits at a useful early point in this literature. It is recent enough that no peer-reviewed empirical study of it yet exists, but late enough in the diffusion curve of consumer-accessible generative video tools (Curran’s reporting indicates he was using Seedance 2.0, a tool that was not consumer-accessible at the time of the 2024 US election) that the production-layer change can be observed with some clarity. It is, in other words, a generative case for a literature that is still scoping itself.

2.4 A production-layer extension

I propose, as a modest theoretical contribution, that the hybrid media system framework be extended with an explicit *production layer*. Chadwick’s framework is most developed at the distribution and amplification ends of the communication chain — how media moves among older and newer nodes, how attention is reallocated across them. The production end is, in the original formulation, largely treated as exogenous: campaigns produce, journalists produce, citizens produce, and the system distributes. What the Pratt case suggests is that the production end is no longer exogenous in any useful sense. Who can produce broadcast-quality political video is now a function of which consumer tools are available, which supporters know how to use them, and which production communities (such as the AI-filmmaking community Curran represents) have organized themselves into informal political production capacity. The production layer has, in effect, become a contested and reshapable site, no longer a stable input to the hybrid media system.

This is a small theoretical move. It is, however, the move that allows the Pratt case to be analyzed as something other than either “campaigns are now distributed” (which is too

vague) or “AI is now a campaign tool” (which is too narrow). The case is best read as a change in *production infrastructure* whose downstream effects are now circulating through the hybrid media system in roughly the ways Chadwick’s framework would predict “but at a speed and on a content register that the framework, written before generative video was consumer-accessible, did not anticipate.

3. The Pratt media ecosystem

3.1 Campaign basics

Spencer Pratt is a forty-two-year-old former reality television personality, husband of the model Heidi Montag, and a public figure best known for his decade-plus appearances on MTV’s *The Hills*. He announced his candidacy for Los Angeles mayor on January 7, 2026 “the first anniversary of the Palisades fire that destroyed his family’s home (Time, January 2026). His stated motivation: “Business as usual is a death sentence for Los Angeles, and I’m done waiting for someone to take real action.” He registered as a Republican in a nominally nonpartisan race, in a city whose electorate is, by registration and recent vote shares, heavily Democratic. The primary was scheduled for June 2, 2026.

Pratt’s principal opponents were the incumbent, Karen Bass, and Councilwoman Nithya Raman. Polling through the spring of 2026 traced a trajectory atypical of celebrity candidacies: in March, Bass led with 20%, Pratt at 10%, Raman at 9%, and undecideds at 51%; by mid-May, Bass was at 30%, Pratt at 22%, Raman at 19%, and undecideds had collapsed to 16% (KTLA / Emerson, May 2026). On the funding side, Pratt and Raman each raised roughly \$530,000 since their February announcements; Bass had raised about \$494,000 in the cycle but \$2.8 million since 2024, with roughly \$2.3 million cash on hand (TheWrap, May 2026). Pratt closed the cycle-on-cycle fundraising gap; Bass retained the institutional money advantage. A May 2026 NBC4/Telemundo 52 debate, by most published accounts, scored as a Pratt win on rhetorical performance “the *Los Angeles Times* described Raman as “inexperienced, touchy, and unprepared” (LA Times, May 2026) “after which Bass canceled a subsequent scheduled debate, citing a Sacramento meeting on Palisades recovery funding (Daily Signal, May 2026).

I rehearse these basics because the analytic argument depends on a non-trivial point: Pratt is not a vanity candidate. He sits at 22% in a credible poll, has out-raised the incumbent in the current cycle, has won at least one televised debate by the assessment of contemporary observers, and has had his opponents respond to him substantively in national broadcast media. Whether his campaign succeeds in the June primary is, as of this writing, an open question. But it is no longer plausible to treat his media ecosystem as the noise of a celebrity stunt; it is a real campaign whose principal media strategy involves the configuration this article describes.

3.2 Four artifacts

Four media artifacts are sufficient to anchor the typology this article develops. Each is described briefly here; the analytic implications are developed in Section 4.

The *Batman / Dark Knight Rises* ad (early May 2026) was produced by Charlie Curran of Menace Studios, an LA-based AI filmmaking shop of approximately four staff. Curran is a commercial filmmaking veteran; he began posting AI political spoofs in January 2026, accumulating tens of millions of views before the Pratt artifact. He reports using tools including Seedance 2.0. The ad depicts LA as Gotham under aristocratic misrule (Bass as Joker, Newsom as cake-eating Marie Antoinette, Harris vodka-chugging), with Pratt as Batman leading citizens to throw tomatoes at the elites. It echoes the mob-rule trial scenes of *The Dark Knight Rises*. Within roughly twenty-four hours of posting, it had drawn 3.9 million views on X, 10,000 reposts, and elite amplification from Bush, Cruz, and Gaetz. Pratt did not commission the ad. Curran has no formal campaign affiliation. Pratt reposted it.

The “*Spencer, Saca La Bassura*” video (released March 30, 2026 on YouTube; circulated heavily on TikTok and Instagram Reels) was produced by Adrian E. Alvarez, a Cuban-American account holder who runs Latinos Por Pratt and splits his time between Miami and Los Angeles. The video is an AI-animated salsa music video whose title puns on Bass’s surname and the Spanish word for trash (“saca la basura” = “take out the trash”). Pratt is depicted wheeling out a trash bin containing Bass; street-party scenes feature dancing and flags; lyrics roast Bass for international travel during LA crises. The artifact has its own dedicated domain (sacalabassura.com). Latinos Por Pratt also produced “Wanted Out of Office” posters. Gustavo Arellano of the *Los Angeles Times*, in a column on the video, argued that the artifact’s salsa instrumentation, Cuban Spanish lexicon (*carajo*, *f---jame*, *mi gente*), and Miami-inflected sensibility read poorly in a city whose Latino population is overwhelmingly Mexican; a corrido in Mexican Spanish would, he argued, have hit the register the supporter was reaching for (Arellano, *LA Times*, April 2026). The “Saca La Bassura” video is the campaign’s clearest evidence of *cultural-fit failure* in supporter-generated AI media.

The “*Fresh Prince of Bel-Air*” parody (May 18, 2026) is the artifact most often treated by media observers as Pratt’s most cinematic move, and the one most easily misclassified. It was posted to Pratt’s own Instagram and is a parody of Will Smith’s *Fresh Prince* theme song. Pratt raps the story of the Palisades fire displacing him: “In West Los Angeles, Palisades, in my backyard is where I spent most of my days,” before driving an Airstream around the streets of Los Angeles. At one point, he spray-paints “They let us burn!” on a barricade; the video ends with him pulling up to the Hotel Bel-Air. The Hotel Bel-Air ending triggered a backlash and a KTLA story in which Pratt denied living at a luxury hotel. This is *campaign-produced* content “Pratt himself rapped the parody, produced it as a candidate, and posted it from his own verified account. It belongs in the campaign-produced row of the typology, not the supporter-generated row.

The “*They Not Like Us*” video (April 2026) is, according to NBC News reporting, a piece “commissioned by his campaign” that “went viral last month.” It plays on Kendrick Lamar’s hit and films Pratt outside Mayor Bass’s mansion, outside Councilmember Raman’s “\$3 million mansion,” and then pivots to Pratt’s own Airstream sitting on the scorched lot where the Palisades home stood. The video drives a “them versus us”

outsider message keyed to Pratt's loss-of-home narrative. As commissioned content, it belongs in the *campaign-produced* row, though it is closer to the boundary with vendor-produced traditional campaign advertising than the Fresh Prince parody, which is wholly candidate-generated.

3.3 The amplification stack

The four artifacts cited above traveled through what is, in retrospect, a recognizable amplification stack. The Batman ad's path from Curran's X account to Jeb Bush's social presence to *The Hollywood Reporter* to international cable news ran roughly thus: (1) supporter posts artifact to X with no formal campaign coordination; (2) Pratt's own social channels repost within hours; (3) ideologically aligned elite figures (Bush, Cruz, Gaetz) circulate within days; (4) entertainment-industry trade press (Hollywood Reporter, TMZ) covers; (5) mainstream broadcast and digital news (NBC, CBS, ABC7, CNN) covers, often with the angle "AI videos shake up political playbook"; (6) the opposing campaign responds, generating a second news cycle (Bass's CNN interview, the Washington Examiner pickup of her response). Each layer compresses the time between artifact and event; each layer also reshapes the artifact's meaning, as the entertainment press encodes it as spectacle and the political press encodes it as a "new political reality."

This amplification stack is, on inspection, hybrid in exactly the sense Chadwick's framework predicts. What is distinct about the Pratt case is the supplier at the very first stage. In 2016 or 2020, the first stage would typically have been an organic meme — a screenshot, a clip remix, a still image. In 2026, the first stage is a ninety-second cinematic short film produced over a weekend by a single AI filmmaker. The amplification stack has not changed; what has changed is what gets fed into it.

4. Analysis: a three-tier typology and what it implies

4.1 The typology

I distinguish three tiers of media production in the Pratt ecosystem.

Tier I: campaign-produced content. Material produced or directly commissioned by the candidate or formal campaign. In the Pratt case, this tier includes the Fresh Prince parody (Pratt's own production), the "They Not Like Us" video (campaign-commissioned), and the campaign's owned channels (mayorpratt.com, the official social accounts, official statements, paid advertising). This tier exhibits more conventional cost structure: it requires direct campaign expenditure, it travels through formal approval, and it carries the candidate's direct attribution.

Tier II: supporter-generated AI content. Material produced by ideologically aligned supporters without formal campaign coordination, using consumer-accessible generative AI tools, and circulated through the supporter's own social channels. In the Pratt case, this tier includes the Batman ad and the broader Curran/Menace Studios catalog (the lightsaber duel ad, the John Wick — style ad, the "Hollywood sign burning" sequence), as

well as the Latinos Por Pratt artifacts (the “Saca La Bassura” video, the “Wanted Out of Office” posters). This tier exhibits a new cost structure: production cost approaches zero (a weekend of one filmmaker’s labor and a Seedance 2.0 subscription), but the *human capital* cost “the supporter’s existing production skill, cultural knowledge, and aesthetic judgment” varies dramatically across producers. The Curran artifacts and the Alvarez artifacts both belong in Tier II but they are not interchangeable; Tier II is internally stratified by the supporter’s production skill and cultural fit.

Tier III: journalist and influencer amplification. Coverage and commentary by news organizations, entertainment-industry trade press, elite political figures, and large-platform influencers. In the Pratt case, this tier is unusually diverse: it includes the entertainment press (Hollywood Reporter, TMZ, Parade, Reality Tea), the partisan-conservative press (Fox News, Daily Caller, Townhall, Daily Signal, Washington Examiner), the tech-policy press (NBC News tech desk, GovTech), the local LA press (KTLA, LA Times, ABC7), the mainstream political press (CNN, NPR, the Washington Post Ripple, The Hill), and ideologically aligned individuals with large followings (Jeb Bush, Ted Cruz, Matt Gaetz, Joe Rogan, Donald Trump). The amplification is itself heterogeneous “different outlets are encoding the same artifact through different frames. The entertainment press treats the Batman ad as spectacle; the tech-policy press treats it as evidence of a new political reality; the partisan press treats it as evidence of an embattled Democratic mayor; the local press treats it as a regional curiosity. The *content* the audience encounters is not just the artifact but the artifact-as-framed.

The typology in compact form:

Tier	Production source	Cost structure	Attribution	Primary example
I	Campaign / candidate	Conventional	Direct	Fresh Prince parody; “They Not Like Us”
II	Supporters using generative AI	Near-zero marginal	Diffuse / contested	Batman ad; “Saca La Bassura”
III	Journalists / influencers	Variable	Editorial / personal	CNN, NBC, Hollywood Reporter, Bush, Cruz, Rogan

Two observations are worth pulling out before the implications. *First*, the tiers are not sealed; they leak. Pratt reposts Tier II content from his Tier I channels. Tier III actors (Bush, Cruz) circulate Tier II content and become, in effect, secondary distributors. The campaign-commissioned “They Not Like Us” video circulates through Tier III channels in ways that blur its formal Tier I origin. The typology is analytic, not phenomenological; it is a scheme for clarity, not a fence around the artifacts. *Second*, the three tiers are not in zero-sum competition for the audience’s attention. They feed each other. The Batman ad would not have reached 3.9 million views without Tier III amplification; the Tier III amplification

would not have occurred without the supporter-generated artifact at Tier II to amplify. The three tiers are functionally interdependent in roughly the way the hybrid media system framework would predict.

4.2 Implication 1: production-cost asymmetry partially offsets resource asymmetry

The clearest implication of the typology is that supporter-generated AI media partially offsets the traditional resource asymmetries between well-funded incumbents and outsider challengers. Bass has the institutional money advantage — \$2.3 million in cash on hand, the established PAC support, the union endorsements. In a 2016 or 2020 cycle, that advantage would have translated nearly directly into a media-production advantage: more ads, better production, more reach. In the 2026 cycle, the relationship between money and media production is mediated by a new fact: a single AI filmmaker working over a weekend can produce a piece of cinematic political video that out-performs (on engagement metrics, on elite circulation, on news coverage) anything Bass’s campaign produced in the same window. The Curran Batman ad cost Pratt’s campaign nothing; it generated more national attention than any single piece of Bass advertising that month.

The qualifier *partially* deserves emphasis. The supporter-generated production-cost reduction does not offset all of the asymmetries. Bass retains the institutional endorsement network, the ground-game capacity, the donor base, the policy machinery. Supporter-generated AI media has no obvious equivalent contribution to make to those. What it does is collapse one specific cost — the cost of producing memorable, broadcast-quality, attention-grabbing political video — and in so doing change the production-side terms on which the air war is fought. This is not a small change. But it is also not a complete change. Campaigns that internalize supporter-generated media as their core production strategy without addressing the ground-game and institutional dimensions of contemporary campaigns are unlikely to be served well by the substitution.

4.3 Implication 2: production-skill stratification and cultural-fit failure

Inside Tier II, the cost of *production* approaches zero, but the cost of *production skill* and *cultural knowledge* remains. The contrast between the Curran artifacts and the Alvarez artifacts is the cleanest available illustration. Curran is a commercial filmmaking veteran with an LA studio; his Batman ad is competently composed, narratively coherent, aesthetically deliberate. The aesthetic register is precisely the register the supporter community he is reaching responds to: cinematic, mythic, dystopian. Alvarez is, on available reporting, working alone, and producing for a community he does not belong to. The Arellano critique — that the salsa instrumentation, the Cuban Spanish lexicon, and the Miami sensibility misfire in a city whose Latino population is overwhelmingly Mexican — is, on the cultural evidence Arellano marshals, basically correct. A corrido in Mexican Spanish would have fit; a salsa in Cuban Spanish does not.

This matters for the broader argument because it identifies what is likely to be the characteristic vulnerability of the “supporters as ad agency” configuration. Generative AI

lowers the cost of *producing* culturally targeted content. It does not lower the cost of *knowing which culturally targeted content will resonate*. A supporter who knows the community produces well; a supporter who only thinks they know the community produces poorly. In an open-source production environment, both kinds of supporters can produce. The campaign’s curatorial function “what it amplifies, what it lets pass without amplification” matters increasingly as the volume of supporter production rises.

Pratt’s amplification choices on this point are, on the available evidence, not always discriminating. He reposted “Saca La Bassura” without (publicly) flagging the cultural-fit concerns. The Arellano critique was therefore a critique not only of Alvarez but of Pratt’s curatorial judgment. For a campaign whose stated value proposition is that it understands LA better than the incumbent, this is not a small problem. The Tier II opportunity (supporters produce content at near-zero marginal cost) carries a Tier II governance problem (the campaign must develop an amplification discipline that distinguishes supporter content that earns repost from supporter content that does not).

4.4 Implication 3: attribution, accountability, and the “fan-made” frame

The third implication is the most difficult and the most consequential. When Bass on CNN described the AI artifacts as “a very dangerous trend” “citing in particular a clip showing her and Newsom drowning in a reservoir” she was raising an attribution question for which the present legal and normative infrastructure has no settled answer. Who is accountable for the content of a supporter-generated AI video that the candidate amplifies? The supporter, who created it? The candidate, who amplified it? Both? Neither? Pratt’s own description of the videos as “fan-made” (in a now-deleted Instagram clip, per NPR) is precisely the attribution-evading move the configuration enables: he is not the author, the supporter is not officially affiliated, and the amplification is “just” a repost.

The field has begun to grapple with related questions for traditional online political content (the literature on coordinated inauthentic behavior, on platform liability, on “Astroturfing”), but the supporter-generated AI configuration introduces a new wrinkle. The supporter is not inauthentic “Curran is a real LA filmmaker; Alvarez is a real account holder. The content is not strictly campaign content” it was not commissioned, no money changed hands, the campaign has plausible deniability. And yet the candidate’s amplification gives the content a status it would not otherwise have, and the candidate clearly benefits from the artifact’s reach. The configuration creates, structurally, a space of attributable-but-deniable campaign content. The 2024-cycle scholarship has begun to flag the problem; the 2026 Pratt case makes it concrete.

For the field, this implies that the next several years will need to develop better conceptual and methodological tools for studying *amplification-as-authorship*. The relevant question is not only who produced an artifact but who chose, with what effect, to amplify it.

5. Forward-looking: implications for 2028

The temptation, in writing about a single case, is to extrapolate to a future the case does not yet warrant. I want to resist that temptation while still saying something useful about what the Pratt configuration plausibly implies for the 2028 cycle.

First, the production-layer change is irreversible at the technology level. The consumer-accessible generative video tools that allowed Curran to produce the Batman ad on a weekend will, by the 2028 cycle, be more capable, cheaper, and more widely distributed. The supplier population at Tier II will grow. The number of supporter producers per major campaign will likely move from a handful to dozens or hundreds. The volume of supporter-generated AI political video in circulation in 2028 will, on any reasonable diffusion curve, dwarf 2026 volumes.

Second, the curatorial problem will intensify in proportion. If a major campaign in 2028 receives hundreds of supporter-generated AI artifacts per week, the campaign's amplification choices become a meaningful strategic asset. The capacity to triage supporter content "to recognize the Curran-quality artifacts and to flag the Alvarez-style cultural-fit failures *before* amplification" will become a campaign capability, not a discretionary task. Whether it is housed in the digital team, the surrogate-operations team, or a new "supporter relations" function is an open organizational question; that it will need a home is, on the present evidence, clear.

Third, the elite-amplification stack (Tier III as described above) will adapt to expect supporter-generated AI artifacts as a normal input. Entertainment-industry trade press will likely build dedicated coverage capacity; partisan elite figures will likely develop more disciplined amplification patterns; mainstream political press will need methodological tools for assessing the campaign-versus-supporter attribution question at speed. The Pratt cycle is the first in which Tier III actors had to figure out how to cover Tier II content; the 2028 cycle will be the first in which they will be expected to do so routinely.

Fourth, the persuasion-versus-consolidation question "does supporter-generated AI media move persuadable voters, or does it simply consolidate the sympathies of existing supporters?" remains open and is likely to be the central empirical question of the 2028 cycle for political communication scholars. The Pratt case provides preliminary evidence for *consolidation*: Pratt's polling movement from March (10%) to May (22%) tracks a moment in which the undecided pool collapsed from 51% to 16%, and on present evidence it is not possible to attribute the share gain principally to supporter-generated AI media as opposed to debate performance, the cumulative effect of his loss-of-home narrative, or the broader anti-incumbent dynamic the *Washington Post* and *Hill* commentary has emphasized. The artifacts plausibly contributed; whether they contributed *more than* or *differently from* conventional campaign communications is not yet knowable.

Fifth, the cultural-fit failure mode identified in Section 4.3 will likely become a more visible failure mode as the volume of supporter content rises. Campaigns that internalize

supporter-generated AI media as a strategy without internalizing the curatorial discipline that prevents the Alvarez-style misfires will likely accumulate cultural-fit failures at scale.

Sixth, the attribution and accountability problem identified in Section 4.4 will likely require explicit normative or regulatory address by the 2028 cycle. The structural feature that supporter-generated AI content is attributable but deniable is, in a system without intervention, a feature that scales with the volume of supporter content. The platforms, the campaigns, the regulatory bodies, the courts, and the press all have plausible interventions; none has, as of this writing, made one.

A practitioner-facing implication, briefly stated: campaigns preparing for the 2028 cycle should not treat the Pratt configuration as a gimmick of a single celebrity candidate. They should treat it as an emerging baseline layer of campaign infrastructure. The relevant questions for 2028 strategy planning are not whether to engage supporter-generated AI media “the supporters will produce regardless” but how to recognize, triage, amplify, and (where necessary) disavow it. Campaigns that treat the Tier II layer as exogenous noise will be out-produced; campaigns that treat it as an extension of paid media will be out-priced; campaigns that treat it as a curatorial problem and develop the necessary internal capability will be best positioned.

6. Conclusion

This article has used the 2026 Los Angeles mayoral campaign of Spencer Pratt as a generative case for examining a configuration of political media production in which supporters, not just campaigns, produce cinematic, culturally targeted political video using consumer-accessible generative AI tools and circulate it through their own and the candidate’s social channels. I have argued that the configuration is best understood through Chadwick’s hybrid media system framework, extended with an explicit production layer that recognizes generative AI as an infrastructural change in who can produce broadcast-quality political video. I have offered a three-tier typology (campaign-produced, supporter-generated, journalist/influencer amplification) and used it to identify three implications: a partial offset of traditional resource asymmetries, a new production-skill stratification with cultural-fit failure as its characteristic vulnerability, and an attribution-and-accountability problem that the field’s present conceptual tools do not yet fully address.

The article’s empirical anchor is one case in one race. The contribution is not a settled finding about how generative AI is reshaping political communication; it is a clarification of the *configuration* that the field will be examining in dozens of cases across the 2026 and 2028 cycles. The Pratt case is unusually clean because the supplier population at Tier II is small enough to name (Curran, Alvarez, a handful of others), the artifacts are few enough to describe in detail, and the press response is well documented. The 2028 cases will not be this clean. That is, in part, the point. The cases will be messier because the configuration will be more diffuse; the analytic clarity available in the Pratt case is, on present evidence, the clarity of a phenomenon at the front edge of its diffusion curve.

The configuration's normative implications are mixed. On the cost-of-production side, it partially democratizes the production of political media in ways that may, on balance, serve outsider candidates well. On the cultural-fit and attribution sides, it introduces failure modes that the field has not yet developed the tools to recognize or address. The honest summary, on the present evidence, is that we do not yet know whether the configuration on net improves or degrades the quality of political communication. We know that it is here, that it is likely to grow, and that we owe the field better empirical and conceptual purchase on it than we currently have.

I leave the article with three open empirical questions for the field: *Does supporter-generated AI political content persuade marginal voters, or only consolidate existing sympathies? Under what conditions does supporter-generated AI content earn cultural resonance, and under what conditions does it fail (as the “Saca La Bassura” case suggests is possible)? How should the field operationalize attribution and accountability in a campaign environment in which the most reach-effective content is attributable-but-deniable?* These are, I take it, the three central questions for the 2028 research agenda.

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Selected press coverage of the 2026 Los Angeles mayoral race used as empirical material for this article includes reporting from *The Hollywood Reporter*, *The Hill*, *NBC News*, *CNN*, *NPR*, *The Los Angeles Times*, *KTLA*, *TMZ*, *ABC7 Los Angeles*, *Fox News*, *Parade*, *CBS*

Sacramento, Newsweek, The Washington Post (Ripple), The Daily Caller, The Washington Examiner, TheWrap, GovTech, Time, and Reality Tea. [A full, annotated source list is maintained on this site's Literature Review page.](#)

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